

Life application task

Key objective: Create an online account at SSA.gov, check your earnings record, and see your estimated retirement and disability benefits.

In the past, people would receive an annual statement from SSA which included their yearly earnings history, as well as an estimate of their monthly benefits. Now, it is all done online. The official website for the Social Security Administration is <https://www.ssa.gov/>

1. Create an account (or sign in if you previously created an account) at <https://www.ssa.gov/myaccount/>. Please note that if you don't have a social security number, you won't be able to create an account. Also, if you don't have a credit card or other credit history, you might not be able to create an account *online*. Why? Because SSA has partnered with the credit bureau, Equifax, to use their identity screening software. This is done for your own protection, to make it less likely that someone else can fraudulently sign into your SSA account. Likewise, if you have frozen your accounts at the major credit bureaus, you won't be able to create a SSA account unless you temporarily unfreeze them first. However, you will be able to access your SSA account if you previously set one up. If you have trouble creating an account online, you can do it in person at an SSA office. **If you can't create an account, then don't upload this life app activity (choose a different one later in the course).**
2. Under the “**Eligibility and Earnings**” section, what does it say?
 - a. Have you earned enough credits yet to qualify for retirement benefits? Yes or **No**
 - b. If not, how many credits have you earned so far? **0**
3. Under the same section, click on the link that says “**Review your full earning record now**”. You can check for errors by comparing what SSA shows for your earnings against Box 3 of your W-2 tax forms. NOTE: If you had pre-tax payroll deductions (such as health insurance premiums) taken out of your paycheck, the amount in Box 3 will be lower than your gross wages and salary shown in Box 1.
 - a. Does your earnings history look correct? **Yes**_____ No_____. If no, click on the “contact us about errors” link and follow up with SSA.
4. Now look at the “**Plan for Retirement**” section. You should find the answers to these questions, although if you don't have enough credits, they may not give you estimates:
The retirement calculator section reads “You aren't currently insured for Retirement benefits, but you may be able to receive benefits from a current spouse or former spouse.”
 - a. What is your estimated monthly benefit at Full Retirement Age? _____
 - b. At early retirement? _____
 - c. At Delayed retirement? _____
5. Now look under the “**More benefits**” section.
 - a. Do you have enough credits to receive Disability Benefits? **NO**

- b. If so, how much a month? **N/A**
 - c. At what age will you qualify for Medicare Part A and Part B? **65**
- 6. Now go back to the top of the home page. Notice that there is a link to download your social security statement, and another link to replace your social security card.
- 7. **Now that you have an account set up, you should check it every year.** Pick a date, like your birthday, to do it so that it becomes a habit. If you use an electronic calendar, add this to your calendar as a repeating annual event. **9/01/20XX (Day after Birthday)**